

THE SHADOW OF THE SAAS

She remains evil but with a reason

Surekha Sikri's rare appearance in a television serial is not only literal. It's metaphorical too. The 64-year-old actor, who plays Daadi-sa on *Balika Vadhu*, went missing in action from the small screen once characters, according to her, became inane. As the mother-in-law, her return symbolises the ushering in of the new saas. Make no mistake, on prime time, the saas is still the bahu's nemesis, but the rules of the game are different. Unlike earlier, she isn't evil without reason. Meghna Malik, who plays the towering Ammaji in Colors' *Laado*, a show about female foeticide, is a woman who's grown up in a man's world. "Her longing for a male child is because of the mindset of people around her," says Malik. These are characters that Purnendu Shekhar calls regressively progressive.

BALIKA VADHU'S SIKRI (LEFT) AND MALIK WHO PLAYS AMMAJI IN LAADO



Vivek Bahl, 41

Creative Director, Star Plus

Most knew it, but few at Star Plus would have admitted that the channel's programming was like a boulder falling down. But Vivek Bahl wasn't one of them. "It was a challenge to push this boulder up," says Bahl, the 41-year-old senior creative director, fiction. He commissioned *Bidaai*, according to Bahl "the cheapest Star show", to Rajan Shahi, the director of *Jassi Jaisi Koi Nahin*. The small show worked, edging out eight years of dazzling drama and lacklustre scripts. Within a year, in 2008, Star Plus gave up its K ghost. With Bahl, a commerce graduate, at the helm, the channel now has an entire programming line-up with content for everyone.



Vivek Bahl and Ashwini Yardi, both now heading the creative teams at Star Plus and Colors respectively. Channels today are not afraid of commissioning newer content, whether that means reviving the horror genre with *Koi Aane Ko Hai* on Colors or putting a thriller on prime time with *Chehra* on Star Plus. "I'm glad *Balika Vadhu* got made now. It would have been polluted if not presented in the right way," says Purnendu Shekhar of the story he wrote in 1992. Children seem to have become the next big thing too, especially with Colors.

Things on TV might be changing but according to media planners, high TRPs might not necessarily translate into high advertising rates. If a show like *Kyunki...* at its prime commanded anything between Rs 2 lakh and 3 lakh for a 10-second ad slot, *Balika Vadhu* generates revenue of close to Rs 1 lakh per 10 seconds. Star Plus, because of its long stint as

number one status, fares a little better. Ad rates on *Bidaai* and now *Yeh Rishta...* go for at least 25 per cent more than that of *Balika Vadhu*. In the second rung of shows, rates dip drastically with *Uttaran* or *Chhoti Bahu* going for half of what the top players command.

Betis may have replaced bahu, kanjeevarams may have given way to kurtis but there are some things on TV that remain the same. The target audience remains primarily female and shows still centre round the suffering woman. But the bigger reason, according to channels, is once again the audience's lack of patience. The 15- to 24-year-old female is the most susceptible to change. To catch the attention of this group, it is important that shows now have a protagonist these young women can relate to. She was *Kyunki's* Tulsi a few years ago, today she's *Balika's* Anandi. Tomorrow she might be *Yeh Rishta's* Akshara. ■